

Jaundice in Adults

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Reviewed/Revised Aug 2025

In jaundice, the skin and whites of the eyes look yellow. Jaundice occurs when there is too much bilirubin (a yellow pigment) in the blood—a condition called hyperbilirubinemia.

(See also [Overview of Liver Disease](#) and [Jaundice in the Newborn](#).)

Jaundice



This photo shows yellowing of the eyes and skin (jaundice).

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Bilirubin is formed and released when hemoglobin (the part of red blood cells that carries oxygen) is broken down as part of the normal process of recycling old or damaged red blood cells. Bilirubin is carried in the bloodstream to the liver and is excreted in the bile (the digestive juice produced by the liver). Bilirubin is then moved through the bile ducts into the digestive tract, so that it can be eliminated from the body. Most bilirubin is eliminated in stool, but a small amount is eliminated in urine. If bilirubin cannot be moved through the liver and bile ducts quickly enough, it builds up in the blood and is deposited in the skin. The result is jaundice.

Many people with jaundice also have dark urine and light-colored stool. These changes occur when a blockage or other problem prevents bilirubin from being eliminated in stool, causing more bilirubin to be eliminated in urine.

If bilirubin levels are high, substances formed when bile is broken down may accumulate, causing itching all over the body. But jaundice itself causes few other symptoms in adults. However, in [newborns with jaundice](#), very high bilirubin levels (hyperbilirubinemia) can cause a form of brain damage called kernicterus.

Many diseases that cause jaundice, particularly severe liver disease, cause other symptoms or serious problems. In people with liver disease, these symptoms may include nausea, vomiting and abdominal pain, and small spiderlike blood vessels that are visible in the skin (spider angiomas, also called vascular spiders). Men may have enlarged breasts and shrunken testes.

Spider Angiomas



Spider angiomas are small, bright-red spots that are surrounded by tiny blood vessels (capillaries), which resemble spider legs. They are normal in many healthy people. They commonly develop in women who are pregnant or use oral contraceptives and in people who have cirrhosis of the liver.

IMAGE PROVIDED BY THOMAS HABIF, MD.

Serious problems caused by liver disease can include:

- Ascites: Accumulation of fluid within the abdomen
- Coagulopathy: A tendency to bleed or bruise
- Hepatic encephalopathy: Deterioration of brain function because the liver malfunctions, allowing toxic substances to build up in the blood, reach the brain, and cause changes in mental function (such as confusion and drowsiness)
- Portal hypertension: High blood pressure in the veins that bring blood to the liver, which can lead to bleeding in the esophagus and sometimes stomach

If people eat large amounts of food rich in beta-carotene (such as carrots, squash, and some melons), their skin may look slightly yellow, but their eyes do not turn yellow. This condition is not jaundice (it is called carotenemia) and is unrelated to liver disease.

Did You Know...

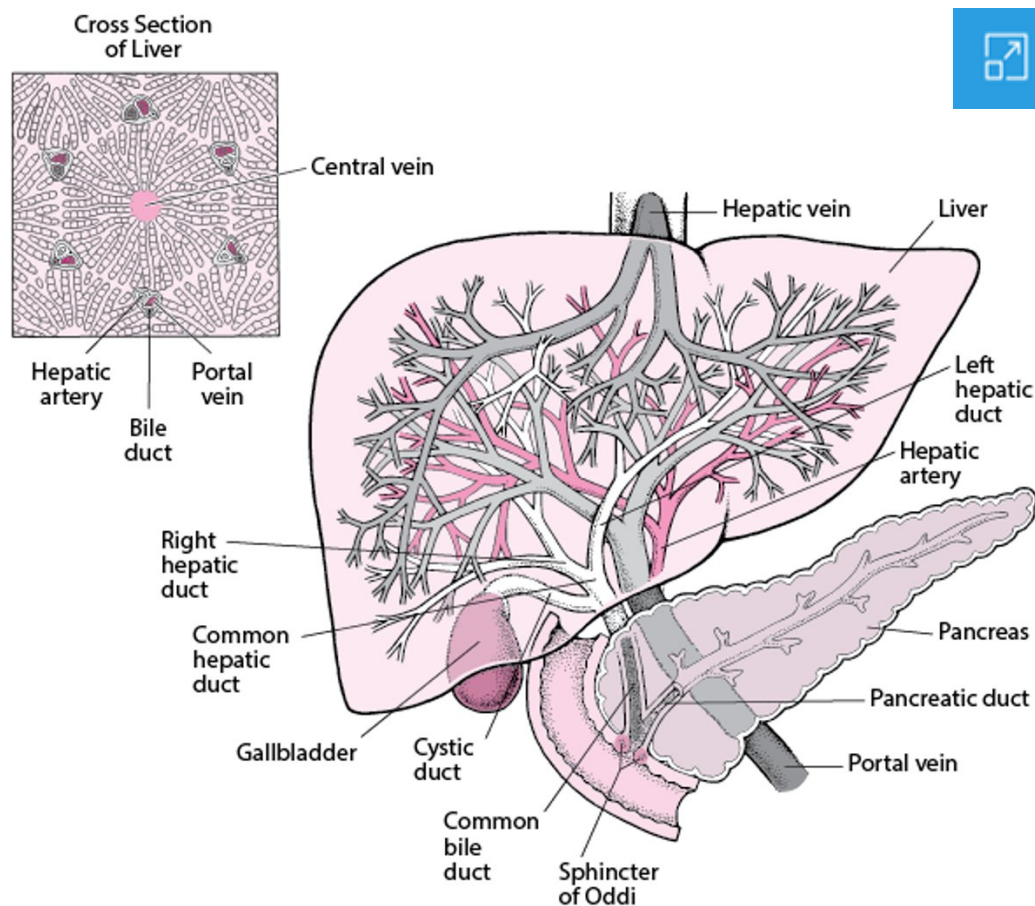
- Eating too many carrots can make the skin look yellow, but this effect is not jaundice.

Causes of Jaundice

Jaundice in adults has many causes. Most causes involve disorders and drugs or medications that:

- Damage the liver
- Interfere with the flow of bile
- Trigger the destruction of red blood cells (hemolysis), thus producing more bilirubin than the liver can handle

View of the Liver and Gallbladder



The **most common causes** of jaundice are:

- [Hepatitis](#)
- [Alcohol-related liver disease](#)
- A blockage of a bile duct by a [gallstone](#) (usually) or [tumor](#)
- A [toxic reaction](#) to a drug, medication, or medicinal herb

Hepatitis

[Hepatitis](#) is liver inflammation that is usually caused by a virus but can be caused by an autoimmune disorder or use of certain drugs or medications. Hepatitis damages the liver, making it less able to move bilirubin into the bile ducts. Hepatitis may be acute (short-lived) or chronic (lasting at least 6 months). Acute viral hepatitis is a common cause of jaundice, particularly jaundice that occurs in young and otherwise healthy people. When hepatitis is caused by an autoimmune disorder or a drug or medication, it cannot be spread from person to person.

Alcohol-related liver disease

Drinking large amounts of alcohol over a long period of time damages the liver. The amount of alcohol and time required to cause damage varies, but typically, people must drink heavily for at least 8 to 10 years.

Bile duct obstruction

If the bile ducts are blocked, bilirubin can build up in the blood. Most blockages are caused by a gallstone, but some are caused by cancer (such as cancer in the pancreas or bile ducts) or rare liver disorders (such as [primary biliary cholangitis](#) or [primary sclerosing cholangitis](#)).

Other causes of jaundice

Some drugs, medications, toxins, and herbal products can also damage the liver (see table [Some Causes and Features of Jaundice](#)).

Less common causes of jaundice include hereditary disorders that interfere with how the body processes bilirubin. They include Gilbert syndrome and other, less common disorders such as Dubin-Johnson syndrome. In Gilbert syndrome, bilirubin levels are slightly increased but usually not enough to cause jaundice. This disorder is most often detected during routine screening tests in young adults. It causes no other symptoms and no problems.

Disorders that cause excessive breakdown of red blood cells (hemolysis) often cause jaundice (see [Autoimmune Hemolytic Anemia](#) and [Hemolytic Disease of the Newborn](#)).

Diagnosis of Jaundice

Jaundice is obvious, but identifying its cause requires a doctor's examination, [blood tests](#), and sometimes other tests.

Warning signs

In people with jaundice, the following symptoms are cause for concern:

- Severe abdominal pain and tenderness
- Changes in mental function, such as drowsiness, agitation, or confusion
- Blood in stool or tarry black stool
- Blood in vomit
- Fever
- A tendency to bruise or to bleed easily, sometimes resulting in a reddish purple rash of tiny dots or larger splotches (which indicate bleeding in the skin)

When to see a doctor

If people have any warning signs, they should see a doctor as soon as possible. People with no warning signs should see a doctor within a few days.

What the doctor does

Doctors first ask questions about the person's symptoms and medical history. Doctors then do a physical examination. What they find during the history and physical examination often suggests a cause and the tests that may need to be done (see table [Some Causes and Features of Jaundice](#)).

Doctors ask when the jaundice started and how long it has been present. They also ask when urine started to look dark (which usually occurs before jaundice develops). People are asked about other symptoms, such as itching, fatigue, changes in stool, and abdominal pain. Doctors are particularly interested in symptoms that suggest a serious cause. For example, sudden loss of appetite, nausea, vomiting, pain in the abdomen, and fever suggest hepatitis, particularly in young people and people with risk factors for hepatitis. Fever and severe, constant pain in the upper right part of the abdomen suggest acute cholangitis (infection of the bile ducts, a medical emergency), usually in people with a blockage in a bile duct.

Doctors ask people whether they have had liver disorders, whether they have had surgery that involved the bile ducts, and whether they take any medications or other substances that can cause jaundice (for example, the prescription medications amoxicillin/clavulanate, chlorpromazine, azathioprine, and oral contraceptives; alcohol; over-the-counter medications; medicinal herbs; and other herbal products such as teas). Knowing whether family members have also had jaundice or other liver disorders can help doctors identify hereditary liver disorders.

Because hepatitis is a common cause, doctors ask particularly about conditions that increase the risk of hepatitis, such as:

- Working at a day care center
- Living in or working at an institution with long-term residents, such as a mental health care facility, prison, or long-term care facility
- Living in or traveling to an area where hepatitis is widespread
- Participating in anal sex
- Eating raw shellfish
- Injecting illicit drugs
- Having hemodialysis
- Sharing razor blades or toothbrushes
- Getting a tattoo or body piercing
- Working in a health care facility without being vaccinated against hepatitis
- Having had a blood transfusion before 1992
- Having sex with someone who has hepatitis
- Having been born between 1945 and 1965

During the physical examination, doctors look for signs of serious disorders (such as fever, very low blood pressure, and a rapid heart rate) and for signs that liver function is severely impaired (such as easy bruising, a rash of tiny dots or splotches, or changes in mental function). They press on the abdomen to check for lumps, tenderness, swelling, and other abnormalities, such as an enlarged liver or spleen.



Some Causes and Features of Jaundice

Cause	Common Features*	Tests†
Liver and gallbladder disorders		
<u>Alcohol-related liver disease</u>	Jaundice that develops slowly	
	A history of heavy alcohol consumption	
	In men, development of feminine characteristics, including loss of muscle tissue, smooth skin, enlarged breasts, shrunk testes, and growth of pubic hair in a female pattern	A doctor's examination Blood tests Sometimes <u>liver biopsy</u>
	Sometimes swelling of the abdomen due to accumulation of fluid (<u>ascites</u>)	
Blockage of a bile duct by a <u>gallstone</u> or, less commonly, by a tumor of the pancreas or bile ducts	Dark urine and light-colored, soft, bulky, oily-looking, and unusually foul-smelling stool	Imaging such as • <u>Ultrasound</u> (done by putting the ultrasound probe on the abdomen) • Endoscopic ultrasound (done with a probe inserted via a flexible viewing tube into the small intestine) • CT cholangiography (<u>CT</u> of the bile ducts done after a
	Usually pain in the upper right part or middle of the abdomen	
	If the cause is a tumor, weight loss and sometimes chronic abdominal pain	



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